mum of 26 per cent under the automatic route—first to 49 per cent and subsequently to 74 per cent. The FDI liberalisation has led to an inflow of Rs 5,700 crore till 2024.

Buoyed by the domestic industry's growing capability, the MoD is increasingly awarding complex projects to the industry, both private and public. In 2023, the MoD signed contracts with the domestic industry for medium power radars and an integrated electronic warfare system (Bharat Electronics), HTT-40 basic trainer aircraft and Dornier-228 aircraft (Hindustan Aeronautics Limited), cadre training ships (L&T), improved Akash Weapon System (Bharat Dynamics Limited), Offshore Patrol Vessels and Missile Vessels (Goa Shipyard Limited and Garden Reach Shipbuilders and Engineers), Fleet Support Vessels (Hindustan Shipyard Limited) and upgraded super rapid gun mount (Bharat Heavy Electrical Limited).

India has also steadily indigenised its military capabilities—warships like the frigate INS *Sahyadri* and the aircraft carrier INS *Vikrant* and the LCA Tejas fighter jet are testimony to that. We have also started exporting military equipment, like the sale of BrahMos missiles to the Philippines.

COMBINING FORCES

The global geopolitical landscape is marked by significant disturbances, including the ongoing Ukraine-Russia conflict, escalating China-Taiwan tensions and persistent instability in West Asia. Additionally, the rivalry between the US and China, characterised by trade wars and military posturing, has further exacerbated global tensions. Forging strategic alliances with global powers such as the US, Russia, Israel and France can facilitate technology transfers, joint military exercises and strategic collaborations. Additionally, engaging in regional security frameworks like the Quadrilateral Security Dialogue (QUAD) enhances cooperative defence strategies and ensures a collective security approach in the Indo-Pacific region.

In terms of structural changes, India appointed a Chief of Defence Staff (CDS) in 2020 to head the newly curated Department of Military Affairs (DMA) to enhance jointness, integration and theaterisation within the Indian military so that the three services utilise their resources in an integrated way. Further, Parliament passed the ISO or the Inter-Services Organisations Act in 2023 to govern the reformed "integrated system" and to regulate the personnel deputed in joint inter-service organisations. India must also establish its theatre commands soon. The creation of military theatre commands and the expansion of our maritime footprint across 'strategic locations' in the Indian Ocean Region (IOR) will improve our overall defence capabilities.

Every military superpower has the ability to project power across their neighbouring seas and oceans. To be counted as one, India has to strengthen its maritime capabilities to secure its interests and project power in the Indian Ocean and beyond. This requires a blue-water navy—comprising modern ships, submarines and aircraft carriers—capable of extended operations and safeguarding trade routes. The IOR's importance in global trade and geopolitical competition is growing, with its vital maritime trade routes serving as 'strategic highways' connecting West and Southeast Asia, East Asia, Europe and the Americas. India is the resident power in the region. While efforts are on to narrow the gap between the Indian and Chinese navies, India's maritime fleet still has only around 150 warships, while China has 370 warships, a number expected to rise to 435 by 2035. India has made some strategic moves to counter China's naval expansion into South Asia.

TAKEAWAYS

- Though India's military inventory and nuclear triad are impressive, it's too dependent on foreign armaments
- Increasing domestic defence production and exports are encouraging
- The IAF is now focusing on exploiting the "air and space continuum" for a "Space Vision 2047"
- Steps towards creating joint military commands are crucial for effective operations

BREACHING AEROSPACE FRONTIERS

In addition to space exploration by the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO), space is now a vital extension of air security too. To that end, the new doctrine of the IAF focuses on effective exploitation of the "air and space continuum" and talks about a "Space Vision 2047". To move from being a "potent air power" to a "credible aerospace power", the IAF plans to deepen its intelligence, surveillance and communication capabilities through the use of space technology. With help from DRDO, ISRO and others, it now plans to develop niche technologies like military satellites to meet India's security objectives, including safeguarding our space-based assets.

With the adoption of latest technologies, cyber capabilities are becoming increasingly important in modern warfare. Developing robust cyber defence mechanisms and offensive capabilities will protect against cyber threats and ensure resilience. India has been taking steps to ensure this.

Economic and industrial support ensures sustained military modernisation. A substantial defence budget, coupled with a strong industrial base, will support continuous innovation and production of advanced military hardware in India. This is imperative if we have to counter the burgeoning military capability of India's main adversary, China. Keeping an aggressive China at bay is India's biggest defence challenge as it marches on in its quest to be among the big boys of world security. ■